

Marines put their skills to good use. Together they made a list of what they hated about the energy drinks currently on the market, resolving to make a nutritional drink with “no empty energy, no niacin flush, no shakes, no jolt, no crash and no nasty chemical aftertaste.” Once they had nailed down a list of the six core functions and identified essential ingredients, Rob started calling manufacturers around the country.

“All the positive things you take out of the military make you a great businessperson or senior staff of a civilian-owned company,” he says. Of course, the product isn’t just for military; civilians love it, too!

Money Mistake: *You’ve Surrounded Yourself with “Yes Men”*

The Fix: *Hire Someone Who’s Not Afraid to Challenge You*

One of the dangers of a family business is that it can be easy to surround yourself with people who will be too soft. Your mom or husband or baby sis may not want to hurt your feelings, so they won’t always tell it like it is. The irony is that the more they cushion you from reality, the more it hurts you. Surrounding yourself with “yes men” or “yes women” is a surefire way to run your business into the ground, because with everyone telling you how great you are, you won’t be able to see the problems and fix them in time.

Rob Dyer’s wife, Anna, works as the unofficial VP of design. That means she has veto power over all the company’s branding and packaging. A while ago, Rob and a handful of other male Marines decided to market an energy drink for women. “We thought we were going to solve all women’s problems,” Rob says with a chuckle. But when he ran the idea by his wife, she said, “What do you and a bunch of male jarheads know about women?”

It didn’t take Rob and the guys long to realize Anna was right. “I was an idiot,” Rob said. Lucky for him, his wife was there to keep him in line.